

TIME IN PRISON: MY STEPS TOWARDS RELEASE

Here you will find, briefly and concretely, everything that helps you organise your daily life — from healthcare and communication to work, study, and leisure.

Our aim is to ensure your safety and provide the support you need.

Informational material produced in collaboration with staff and detainees from Tartu, Tallinn, and Viru Prison.

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Translated from Estonian to English

FOREWORD

The purpose of this material is to give you a clear and understandable overview of how prison life is organised, what your rights and obligations are, and what opportunities you can use while in prison.

This material contains information about what helps you better manage your daily life in prison: for example, healthcare and medical assistance, participation in social programmes, working, studying, and leisure activities. It also describes prison staff and their roles — this information helps you approach the right person with your question and get help more quickly.

This informational material was compiled together with detainees — during its preparation, nearly one hundred detainees across all three Estonian prisons were spoken with and consulted. All topics and recommendations written here have been compiled with information received from detainees.

Please note that this informational material does not replace the prison's internal rules — you must also familiarise yourself with the internal rules and sign them. This material is, however, an additional aid that describes prison rules and opportunities to you in a simpler and more understandable way.

If you feel that something is unclear or you need help, talk to prison staff. They can explain rules, answer questions, and direct you to the services you need. Always ask if something is unclear.

Use this time well — to maintain your health, develop skills, and prepare for life beyond the walls!

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1. ARRIVAL AND RECEPTION INTO PRISON

Hello! You have arrived at prison. It is understandable if you feel uncertain, confused, or anxious right now. Our aim is to ensure your safety and provide the support you need upon arrival. During the first days, several procedures will be carried out with you and information about immediate needs in prison will be shared. It is possible that not everything will happen at once — please be patient, as different activities may take time.

A detainee's journey begins in the holding cell. Personal belongings are not permitted in the holding cell. Items that are permitted in prison can be collected once you are inside. Items that are not permitted in prison will be stored and returned to you upon release. Once the initial procedures have been completed and a suitable cell has been found for you in the residential wing, you will be taken there.

1.1 First Procedures

Search and documents

Upon arrival at prison, you will be searched by an officer of the same sex. All detainees are searched. The purpose of the search is to find prohibited items, which allows us to ensure your safety and that of others in prison. You will be asked to undress for the search, but you will never be completely naked at any point during the search. The search is conducted in a private room.

Your fingerprints will be taken. Photographs of you and your distinguishing features will be taken (e.g. tattoos, scars, etc.).

When you arrive at prison, a personal file is opened for you. The following necessary documents are stored securely there:

- identity document
- court documents
- documents relating to the execution of the sentence

Your identity document will be returned to you upon release from prison.

Health check

After arriving at prison, you will undergo a health check to assess your physical and mental condition and ensure assistance if needed.

Physical health check: Tests for alcohol and drug use will be carried out. A DNA sample will be taken. A medical officer will assess your general state of health, document illnesses (including chronic ones), and ensure that treatment continues where necessary.

Personal medications are not permitted in prison. It is very important that you inform the medical officer of any ongoing treatment at the earliest opportunity. This allows the prison medical staff to provide you with the necessary medications so that you can continue your course of treatment.

Mental health: A medical officer will assess your mental state. If you feel you have mental health problems (e.g. alcohol or drug dependency, suicidal thoughts), be sure to inform your contact officer or a guard. Staff working in prison have received training to deal with such problems and will direct you to specialist appointments.

We recommend maintaining calm during the procedures and when receiving initial information, and being attentive. If anything is unclear, do not hesitate to ask prison staff. Prison has specific rules and a daily schedule, following which will help you adapt to life here.

1.2 Immediate Needs

Your personal belongings, including your mobile phone, have been stored. For phone calls, a phone card will be issued to you in prison; your personal phone cannot be used in prison. At the earliest opportunity, you can make a call to your loved ones from your phone card. More information about this and other matters relating to phone calls can be found in section 2.3.

A personal financial account will be opened for you in prison. This is called your personal account. Through it, you can carry out transactions related to money and payments. Cash is not permitted in prison. Opening your personal account takes a little time; the prison officer dealing with you — your contact officer — will give you the account number and tell you when you can begin using it.

Prison will provide you with basic hygiene items; later you will have the opportunity to buy these yourself. Personal clothing is not permitted in prison; you will be given prison clothing to use, unless you are on remand.

Basic necessities provided:

- Phone card and number
- Personal account number
- Hygiene pack (soap, toothbrush and toothpaste, razor, etc.)
- Prison clothing (jacket, trousers, T-shirt, etc.)
- Footwear (if you do not have any)
- Bedlinen and towel
- Eating utensils

2. PRISON DAILY LIFE

2.1 Daily Schedule and Roll Call

Prison operates on a daily schedule — set times at which detainees wake up, eat, wash, move around, and rest. The daily schedule exists in the interests of order, safety, and structuring your day. The exact schedule can be found in the prison's internal rules. The day in prison generally begins at 06:00 and ends at 22:00.

Main activities during the day:

- The day is filled with studying, work, social programmes, and leisure activities.
- Morning and evening roll calls take place, both in the cell.
- Food is brought three times a day and is also eaten in the cell.
- An outdoor walk takes place once a day, according to a schedule.
- Phone calls are possible outside of activity hours.
- Showering outside the cell takes place according to a schedule.
- Being sent to school or work is arranged by the guard or contact officer.

What does a typical day look like?

06:00 — Wake-up. Electricity comes on. Tidy the cell and attend to hygiene.

06:20–07:15 — Breakfast, followed by morning roll call and medication distribution.

08:00–17:00 — Main activities: studying, working, participating in programmes, leisure.

11:30–12:30 — Lunch. Food is generally brought to your cell.

17:30–18:30 — Evening meal, followed by evening roll call and medication distribution.

22:00 — Quiet hours. Electricity is switched off. As an exception, the wing manager may permit electricity until midnight.

You must be in your cell when the daily schedule requires it — e.g. at mealtimes and when cell doors are locked. Prison has the right to make temporary or exceptional changes to the schedule if necessary for safety or order.

Roll call

Roll call is a daily check during which a prison officer verifies that you are in the right place and everything is in order. You will be notified 10 minutes before roll call.

What you must do during roll call: Be properly dressed with your name badge. Stand in front of your made bed. Keep hands visible; do not lean or sit. Switch off all electrical devices or put them on silent. When asked, state your first and last name clearly. During roll call, do not eat, read, talk, or interfere with roll call.

2.2 Personal Account

A bank account is opened for you in prison to hold your money — this is called your personal account. You will receive your personal account number from your case manager or prison officer.

- If you work in prison, your wages will be transferred to your personal account.
- Family members and other persons outside prison may also transfer money to your personal account.
- You can make bank transfers from your account, e.g. to pay state fees.
- You are required to pay for the electricity used by electrical devices in your cell.

Cash is not permitted in prison.

When money arrives in your personal account:

If there ARE claims against you: 50% goes towards paying your debts; 20% goes to the release fund; 30% remains for your use in prison.

If there are NO claims against you: 70% goes to the release fund; 30% remains for your use in prison.

What is the release fund?

This is a portion of the money received into your personal account that is kept in reserve and given to you upon release. It helps you cover your first expenses after release (e.g. renting accommodation). The maximum size of the release fund is three times the Estonian minimum wage. When the release fund is full, you can decide whether to continue transferring money to it or to use it in prison.

You may give your personal account number to your loved ones. They can send you money if needed. If your family sends you money, it is also divided into portions — e.g. if a family member sends €12, you will have €3.60 available to spend.

2.3 Phone Calls

Phone calls in prison are not a given — they are a right subject to specific rules. These rules depend on which wing you are in and how you behave.

During the first week, you must write down the details and numbers of the people you wish to call. You must fill in a form, which you give to prison staff. You may make calls at the times specified in the daily schedule. Phone calls are chargeable. You will be given a phone card to which you can transfer money from your personal account.

Upon arriving at prison, €1 will be loaded onto your card, which allows approximately 10–20 minutes of talk time.

Open wing

Daily phone usage time is 60 minutes, including dialling, waiting, and call duration.

Restricted communication rights / Closed wing

If you are in a punishment cell, isolated locked cell, or closed wing, you have restricted communication rights. The phone is brought to your cell at a previously agreed time. You can generally make at least one call per week of at least 10 minutes. You must notify a prison officer in writing the day before.

Who may I call?

If calling someone whose details you have not previously submitted, fill in a form by the previous day's evening roll call, stating: your name, date of birth, and cell number; who you wish to call and their number; and how this person is connected to you.

What is prohibited when making calls?

- Sharing your phone card number and PIN with other detainees
- Using another detainee's phone card or logging in with someone else's details
- Leaving the phone without logging out
- Passing the handset to another detainee during your call

2.4 Eating

In prison you receive food three times a day. Food is brought to your cell. At lunchtime, eating may also take place at school or the workplace.

Rules when eating:

- Eating outside the cell is not permitted, except when arranged by prison.
- You must collect your food yourself.
- Food may not be shared with other detainees.
- After eating, return utensils and tray (Tallinn Prison) or wash them yourself (Viru Prison).

Special food

Special food may be obtained if you have a health problem and the prison doctor prescribes it. If you do not eat meat, you may request a meat-free or pork-free diet. In this case, you may not simultaneously buy meat products from the prison shop. If you do not eat meat due to religion or beliefs, notify your contact officer.

You have the right to refuse prison food entirely by submitting a reasoned request, but you must refuse all meals at once, not just one.

2.5 Online Shop

While in prison, you can buy items and food products from the online shop. Your personal account must contain the required sum.

The online shop sells: food items (bread, cheese, tinned goods, confectionery, coffee, tea, seasonings); clothing (socks, T-shirts, underwear); hygiene products (soap, shampoo, toothpaste, razors); stationery and small items (notebooks, pens, batteries, combs, games); electronic devices permitted in cells (television, kettle).

Orders are placed on the prison tablet on certain days (usually twice a month). Goods usually arrive the following week. A service fee is added to the price.

Rules and restrictions:

- Some products may only be purchased by women (e.g. sanitary pads, mascara).
- Various quantity restrictions apply — check the prison's internal rules.
- Electronic devices receive a security label before being given to you.
- If you exceed the quantity limit, goods will not be given to you but the money is still deducted.
- Once an order is placed, you must collect the goods; if you refuse, you must still pay.
- If you have a penalty prohibiting additional food purchases, you may only buy consumable goods.

2.6 Living Cell

In prison you share a cell with another detainee. Prison assigns you a cell, a bed, and a shelf. In the day room there is a shared refrigerator with an assigned space for you. A doctor may assign the lower bunk for health reasons.

Cell furnishings:

Bunk bed, table, two chairs, two shelves, coat hook, toilet, and washbasin. A cell terminal next to the door allows you to listen to the radio and call the guard room.

Cell maintenance

Prison provides bedding and a towel, plus cleaning supplies. You must keep clean: your bed and personal items, the entire cell including the toilet, and the wing's common areas. During roll call your bed must be made. Useless items must not accumulate — dispose of empty packaging. You may have a total of up to 30 kg of items in your cell and storage combined.

Cell rules — NOT permitted:

- Exchanging beds, shelves, or refrigerator compartments with fellow detainees
- Shouting, disturbing others, or breaking quiet hours
- Playing radio/TV too loudly if it disturbs cellmates
- Receiving items or food from, or giving them to, other detainees
- Throwing anything out of the cell or receiving items through windows/doors
- Making changes to cell furnishings (e.g. putting up mirrors)
- Sticking things to walls (a pinboard is provided)
- Covering lamps, cameras, or food hatches
- Fermenting or souring food
- Having self-made electrical devices or tools
- Putting up pictures depicting naked people or inciting hatred

Personal items permitted in the cell:

- Television, kettle, and electric shaver from the prison shop
- Daily-use items: hygiene products, writing materials, study materials, up to 5 books
- Leisure items: games, books, etc.
- Permitted personal clothing (thermal underwear, footwear, etc.)
- Food and drink permitted in prison, in limited quantities

Since your personal items are registered, you may not simply throw them away (except underwear and socks). An application must be made, and items disposed of with your contact officer.

2.7 Personal Hygiene, Clothing, and Washing

In prison it is important to keep yourself and your living environment clean — this is every detainee's obligation. If you do not have enough clothing or hygiene products and have no money to buy them, you may submit a request to prison for assistance.

For washing, use only the shared shower room or the shower in your cell. Hygiene products can be bought from the prison's online shop. Hairdressing services are free. Tattooing by any means is prohibited in prison.

If you have no money for hygiene products, you may request a free hygiene pack (soap, toothbrush, toothpaste, disposable razors; sanitary pads for women). Upon first arrival, these are provided free. Subsequently, you can request a pack every 3 months if your average available balance was below €15/month over the last 3 months.

Clothing

You must wear prison-issued clothing (generally brown-toned trousers and jacket). Remand and open prison detainees may wear personal clothing. Upon arrival, you receive bedding.

Permitted personal items: underwear and thermal underwear; socks; up to 4 pairs of footwear; gloves and scarf; 3 hair ties if you have long hair or a beard.

Prison provides: T-shirt, trousers (long and short), skirt on request for women, jacket and coat, winter and summer hat, mittens and scarf, work clothing (if working); bedlinen, duvet, pillow, towel and sauna towel; indoor and outdoor footwear if needed; up to 2 pairs of socks and underpants.

Clothing can generally be exchanged every 6 months upon request. Clothing will not be provided as charitable assistance if your 3-month average balance is greater than the item's price.

2.8 Laundry and Repairs

Prison clothing and bedlinen laundering is free. Towels and bedlinen are washed every 14 days. Prison and work clothing are washed as needed.

Personal items laundering is chargeable. You can buy washing products from the shop, or send clothing to the laundry per the price list. Underwear, socks, and leather items must be washed by yourself.

Repairs: Prison clothing is repaired free. Personal clothing repair at the prison laundry costs €1.50–€4 per item. Shoe repair costs €1 (free if your 3-month average balance is below €9). Repairs carry no guarantee.

2.9 Visits from Loved Ones

Short-term visit (2 hours)

Meeting with loved ones or other important people. Generally separated by glass. If you wish to meet without glass, you must request this separately.

Long-term visit (24 hours)

Meeting in a separate room with loved ones, a support person, or approved guests. Chargeable; payment by bank card or transfer. Only items bought from the prison online shop may be brought.

Video call visit (1-2 hours)

Video call with loved ones or for administrative purposes (solicitor, chaplain, notary, etc.).

All visits must be registered in advance by phone or request. Start preparing with sufficient notice, as there may be long queues. The visitor must arrive with sufficient time, leave prohibited items at the gatehouse, and may be subjected to alcohol and drug tests.

Prohibited at visits:

- Rude behaviour, insulting, or threatening
- Being under the influence of alcohol or drugs
- Bringing prohibited items into prison
- Leaving items brought by the visitor with the detainee
- Touching intimate areas or sexual activity at short-term visits or video calls

2.10 Correspondence

In prison you can send and receive letters through prison, not directly between individuals. Letters are sent by regular post. Postage is paid from your personal account. In exceptional cases, prison may cover postage for letters to government bodies.

You may write to family members, acquaintances, solicitors, government bodies, and others with whom communication is not restricted by law. You may NOT write to: persons with whom communication is prohibited by court/prison decision; persons whose address cannot be identified or with whom communication may be dangerous.

The content of your letters may only be read if a court has authorised this in connection with criminal proceedings. However, prison may open envelopes in your presence to check for prohibited items. Prison may not check letters to your defence counsel, solicitor, prosecutor, court, Chancellor of Justice, Ministry of Justice, or prison committee.

2.11 Movement Within Prison

Open wing: Cell doors are open during the day; you may move freely within the wing. The day room has a television, books, games, and radio.

Closed cell: You are in your cell 23 hours a day. Movement only with prison officers, according to a schedule.

On prison territory, you always move with and with the permission of a prison officer. You must travel along the designated route and follow instructions.

Not permitted during movement:

- Picking things up from the ground or dropping items
- Physical contact with anyone (handshakes, etc.)
- Engaging in unrelated activities
- Looking through door peepholes or deviating from the route
- Entering rooms without permission
- Crossing the red line before barred doors or touching locks
- Pressing buttons or switches without valid reason

Outdoor walks

Once a day for at least one hour in the designated area. Permitted items: watch, handkerchief, religious item/prayer beads, up to 0.5L water in a plastic bottle, wedding ring, and once a month a duvet and pillow for beating outside.

Outside the cell, you must wear prison clothing and your name badge visibly around your neck. You may not move around bare-chested. Searches may be conducted when entering/leaving the wing.

2.12 Leisure Time in Prison

Library

In an open wing, books are on the wing's shelves, exchanged from time to time. If you cannot find something suitable, submit a request. If transferred, return all books. If you lose or damage a book, you must pay for it.

Magazines and newspapers

Main national dailies and magazines are available. Other publications can be ordered at your own expense. Content with violent or prohibited material is not permitted.

Leisure activities

Various options: art, music, hobby groups. Ask your contact officer or recreation coordinator. Board games are allowed but not for money or items. Gambling is strictly prohibited. Sometimes prison may allow a detainee to lead a hobby group.

Sports

Gym, football pitch, and other facilities. Usually in groups. One training session typically lasts about 1 hour. Open wing may have more time; closed wing and punishment cell have limited opportunities. You engage in sport at your own risk.

2.13 Using the Tablet

The tablet is used primarily for studying and viewing prison information. You cannot freely browse the internet. Tablet use is a privilege, not a right.

Uses: participating in studies; work practice or prison programmes; accessing internal information (daily schedule, rules, study materials); viewing your files and reading legislation; making online shop purchases and checking account balance.

Rules: The tablet is shared prison property. There is a scheduled time for use, and a request must be submitted. All activities are recorded and may be checked. You may not take the tablet apart, change settings, give it to another detainee, or view prohibited content.

Internet access is not freely available. All activities on the tablet are monitored. If you break the rules, you may lose your right to use it. If you damage it, you are responsible for repair costs.

3. COMPLIANCE WITH RULES

Prison is subject to a whole range of rules which you are obliged to follow. These are set out in this material, with further details in the prison's internal rules.

What happens if rules are broken? The prison officer will inform you that the action is inappropriate and order you to change it or stop. If the violation is serious or you do not stop, the officer may terminate your participation in the activity or your escort.

How is a violation responded to? A report is drawn up and forwarded to the contact officer. The contact officer will ask for your explanation and decide whether to limit the matter to a conversation or initiate proceedings, depending on the seriousness, your previous behaviour, and your attitude.

Complying with rules gives you more rights and opportunities in prison. Breaking rules can lead to loss of rights and will significantly delay your opportunity to move to an open prison or be released early. Generally, each disciplinary sanction remains in force for 1 year, but may be ended sooner with good behaviour. Both actions and failures to act may be considered violations (e.g. not participating in household duties).

Disciplinary proceedings

Thorough explanations are taken from all parties and witnesses. You can explain your position. Other evidence is gathered (video, photos). All details are recorded and a decision and penalty are formed. Previous behaviour and attitude are taken into account.

Penalties if convicted:

- Written reprimand
- Personal television, kettle, or electrical device taken away for up to 45 days
- Deprivation of short-term or long-term visits
- Exclusion from work for up to 1 month
- Solitary confinement for up to 14 days (max 3 days for those under 21)

Penalties if on remand:

- Written reprimand
- Prohibition on buying additional food from the online shop for up to 2 months
- Solitary confinement for up to 14 days (max 3 days for those under 21)

Solitary confinement (punishment cell)

You are alone. You must wear punishment cell clothing. No personal items. Visual monitoring. Movement limited; 1 hour outdoors per day. Work, study, and social programme participation may be restricted. Only short-term visits with family; long-term visits may be refused. Phone calls and access to newspapers, books, and TV restricted.

Penalties are typically cleared 1 year after being imposed. Penalties may be imposed with a probationary period (1-6 months). At least 48 hours must separate multiple solitary confinement penalties.

4. MY PHYSICAL AND MENTAL HEALTH

Prison healthcare operates according to clear rules. You will normally undergo an initial health check within the first 24–72 hours after arrival. This identifies previous illnesses and ongoing treatment courses. Inform the doctor immediately — this ensures your treatment does not get interrupted.

In prison you have a practice nurse and a GP, who can refer you to specialists. If you do not have sufficient command of Estonian or Russian, ask for an interpreter.

Medical services available:

Practice nurse and GP: Everyday health concerns, chronic condition monitoring, prescriptions. Free.

Emergency assistance 24/7: Acute pain, trauma, sudden illness. Guard calls duty nurse; ambulance if needed. Free.

Specialists: GP writes a referral; visits in prison or outside; some via video call. Free.

Dental care: Pain treatment free; dentures at own expense.

Psychological and mental health support: Contact practice nurse or contact officer. Free.

Addiction support: Medication and group programmes. Free.

Vision test and glasses: Standard glasses free; special models at own expense.

Special needs assistance: Aids (wheelchair, etc.), linguistic/visual needs. Generally free.

How do I get to see a doctor?

First aid is available around the clock. For emergencies, approach your wing guard immediately. For non-emergencies, fill in an application on a paper form or tablet, or approach your guard or contact officer.

The practice nurse examines you first on working days. The GP comes to prison at least once a week. The GP can refer you to specialists and issue digital prescriptions. The prison pharmacy orders medications, and the on-duty team distributes them at specified times. Your digital health record and previous diagnoses are preserved.

Taking medication

Medications are generally distributed twice daily (morning and evening). Psychotropic medications must be taken in the presence of a medical officer. Medications must be swallowed in front of an officer. Personal medications may not be brought into prison. Do not store, share, sell, or exchange medications. Taking medication under a false name is prohibited.

Psychologist

The psychologist helps you cope with stress, crises, and adjustment difficulties. Conversations observe confidentiality requirements. To see the psychologist, write a request to your contact officer.

If you are in crisis (suicidal thoughts, panic), notify your guard immediately. The duty nurse will respond at the earliest opportunity.

Chaplain and pastoral care

Every Estonian prison has a chaplain providing religious and spiritual support regardless of your denomination. Conversations are voluntary and confidential. Chaplains of different denominations serve: primarily Lutheran and Orthodox, and where possible Catholic and others.

The chaplain can provide: pastoral conversation, sacraments (baptism, communion, confession), religious literature and symbols (Bible, Quran, prayer books, cross, prayer mat).

Emergency medical care is your basic right. You have the right to receive equivalent medical care as a person living in freedom. Queues may be long — seeing a specialist may take months. Your health data is confidential and accessible only to medical staff.

5. MY ACTIVITIES IN PRISON

There are many activities and steps in prison that help move you towards release — this is called resocialisation. Resocialisation is prison's support and activities intended to make it possible for you to live a law-abiding life after imprisonment. These are planned together with you and affect whether and when you may move to an open prison or be released early.

Resocialisation activities:

- Social programmes
- Studying
- Working
- Addiction treatment and psychological counselling
- Maintaining or improving relationships with loved ones
- Pre-release administrative procedures (identity documents, disability assessment, housing/benefits applications)

5.1 Risk Assessment and Individual Sentence Plan (ISP)

Risk assessment seeks to understand how likely it is that you may commit a new offence, and to find solutions. Assessed factors include: financial problems, alcohol/drug dependency, conflict resolution, and whether you may be dangerous to yourself or others. Information is gathered from court decisions, criminal records, employment registers, and specialist interviews.

Risk assessment is carried out for convicted persons with sentences longer than one year, upon arrival and when a court considers early release.

Since risk assessment is based largely on your past life, you cannot change it much. However, when a court considers early release, your character reference — describing your activities and behaviour in prison — is also very important. You can change your habits, behaviour, and mindset, and prison can provide support in learning new skills.

Individual Sentence Plan (ISP)

The ISP is your personal activity plan for your time in prison. It sets out: what you need to do to prepare for release; supporting activities (studying, working, counselling, programmes); dates when you may become eligible for open prison or early release.

The ISP is created by the contact officer in cooperation with you. Monthly reviews take place. The ISP is updated once a year. It is created for convicted persons with sentences longer than one year. Even without an ISP (shorter sentences), you may still participate in activities if places are available.

5.2 Social Programmes

If you have problems with addictive substances, anger management, or a tendency towards violent behaviour, you can participate in social programmes that help you cope better. Programmes support personal development, improve coping, and develop social skills.

Social programmes, together with working and studying, form the core of resocialisation. Participation may improve your chances of moving to an open prison or being released early.

Suitable programmes are agreed during ISP preparation with your contact officer and regularly reviewed. Participation is generally voluntary, but refusal may affect your risk score and reduce your chances of early release.

Available programmes cover: emotion management (“Anger Management” — 9 sessions), social skills and conflict resolution (“Aggression Replacement Training” — 18 sessions), domestic violence, addiction (“Lifestyle 24/7”), drink-driving (“Road Safety Programme”), and programmes on Christian values. Programmes typically run 1–2 times per week in groups of 4–8 or individually.

The social worker does not register you for a programme — notify your contact officer directly. Programme participation alone does not guarantee open prison or early release. If you have a drug dependency, join a support group as soon as possible, especially before release.

5.3 Studying

Why study?

- Prison gives you time to study, making days pass faster.
- You gain knowledge and skills useful after release.
- Classes are small and teachers accommodate learners' needs.
- After release, you can continue studying at an adult school or vocational college.
- Studying reflects positively on you in a judge's eyes if early release becomes possible.

Options:

Basic school (up to 9th grade) — available in Estonian and Russian.

Upper secondary school (10th–12th grade) — Estonian only; language level must be at least A2.

Vocational training — various trades mainly in construction and services. Estonian only; language level at least B1. Different courses at different prisons.

Estonian language study — need and opportunity assessed after conviction or during ISP preparation. Also available for remand detainees.

How to start studying

Studying is agreed during the risk assessment interview and ISP preparation with your contact officer. You can join year-round, even mid-academic year. If you studied before, you continue where you left off. Vocational course places are limited and selected by interview.

School rules:

- Complete tasks assigned by the teacher.
- Do not disrupt class — removal counts as unexcused absence.
- Unexcused absence is not permitted.
- Only bring items needed for studying; take nothing from school without permission.

Remand detainees may study basic or upper secondary education and Estonian language. Vocational training is only for convicted persons. Study is not possible during isolation or when contact with co-accused is restricted.

5.4 Working

Why work?

- Fills your day productively.
- Maintains existing or develops new work skills.
- Earns wages, increasing financial independence.
- Earned money can support your loved ones.
- Shows you positively and may influence your chances of open prison or early release.

Working is mandatory for all convicted detainees. Exemptions: pensioners, remand detainees, those unable to work for medical reasons, and students (during term time, but they must work during holidays).

Work areas:

Household duties: Cleaner, food distributor, dishwasher, cook, baker, kitchen worker, warehouse worker, hairdresser, librarian, seamstress. Usually the first job.

Prison industry (VEK): Carpenter, welder, painter, packer, machine sewing, laundry operator. Requires specific skills or prison-provided training.

Open prison jobs: Construction, logistics, manufacturing, service companies. Your employer must agree to prison conditions.

Wages

Wages are paid to your personal account. The minimum is at least 10% of Estonia's national minimum wage; starting at €0.74 per hour. The same distribution applies as for other personal account income (50% debts / 20% release fund / 30% available if claims exist; 70% release fund / 30% available if no claims).

Workplace behaviour

Follow the work supervisor's instructions, maintain good work pace, take care of tools. Wear your name badge and follow prison rules. Violations lead to reports, penalties, reduced wages, or removal from work. All tools and protective equipment are provided by prison — do not take them to your cell or exchange them.

Tax declaration

If your wages are below the tax-free allowance, you do not need to file. Otherwise, ask your contact officer — the Tax and Customs Board will send you a pre-filled declaration on paper, which you complete and return by post.

6. OPEN PRISON AND CONDITIONAL EARLY RELEASE

We support gradual release and aim to create opportunities to move from closed prison to open prison or to be released early, so that your adjustment is smoother. You may be released early in two ways: to electronic supervision (ETEV) or without electronic supervision (TEV).

Early release eligibility:

Sentences under 5 years: ETEV possible from 1/3 served (min 4 months); TEV from 1/2 served (min 4 months).

Sentences over 5 years: ETEV possible from 1/2 served (min 4 months); TEV from 2/3 served (min 4 months).

6.1 Open Prison

In an open prison, you have more freedom but also greater responsibility. It helps you adjust to normal life and prepares you for release. You continue your ISP, can participate in social programmes, and receive medical care.

Conditions for open prison:

- Your ISP's open prison eligibility date has arrived.
- You are not assessed as highly dangerous.
- You have not previously attempted to escape and are not assessed as an escape risk.
- No recent disciplinary violations.
- No pending criminal cases.
- Required social programmes completed.
- Drug dependency treatment/programme completed (if applicable).

Open prison rules:

Free movement within the open prison territory during daytime. You must be in your room during quiet hours. You may leave only for pre-approved activities (study, work, short outings). You can cook for yourself. You must follow the daily schedule and maintain order in your living space.

You may request short outings of up to 21 calendar days per year. In case of serious family events (serious illness or death), you can request an emergency outing of up to 7 days (not counted against the 21-day limit).

Rule violations may result in warnings, restricted rights, or return to closed prison.

6.2 Serving the Sentence Under Electronic Supervision on Probation

Electronic supervision allows earlier release from prison. You wear an ankle bracelet that monitors your location. Equipment is installed at your residence. You may only leave your home with probation officer permission for limited activities.

Conditions:

- Residence owner confirms you have permission to live there.
- There must be electricity and mobile phone reception.
- The residence must be lockable.
- All adult residents must consent to the equipment.

Duration: 1-12 months, depending on the court's decision. If you violate conditions, you may be returned to prison, and time spent under electronic supervision is not deducted from your sentence.

6.3 Serving the Sentence in Freedom on Probation

Many detainees have the opportunity to be released early and continue serving their sentence in freedom on probation. This means you live in freedom, subject to rules and obligations, with regular meetings with your probation officer.

Requirements:

- Live at the court-designated permanent residence.
- Attend all scheduled meetings with your probation officer.
- Pass alcohol and drug tests.
- May be required to work, study, undergo treatment, or participate in social programmes.
- Compliance is monitored during the probationary period.

If you violate rules, the probation officer will meet with you to understand what happened. You may be directed to programmes or counselling, or required to meet more frequently. For serious or repeated violations, the court may add obligations, extend probation by up to 1 year, or decide to return you to prison.

If you experience difficulties outside prison, always talk to your probation officer — early communication can help prevent problems.

7. RELEASE

Begin preparations for release a few months in advance. Keep the following points in mind; your contact officer can also help you.

Consult your contact officer

Before release, meet with your contact officer. They will advise you on how to prepare for release.

Documents and bank account

Check the validity of your ID card and driving licence and renew them while still in prison if necessary. A valid ID card is needed for signing a lease, applying for benefits, etc. Check that you have a bank account so that your release allowance and other money can be paid directly to it.

Housing and local authority

Contact the local authority where you plan to live or where your residence is registered. You can apply for housing or temporary accommodation there. Under the Social Welfare Act, the local authority will provide initial social assistance and help with basic necessities.

Healthcare and treatment plan

If a treatment plan was prepared in prison (e.g. prescription medication), ensure it continues after release. Find out who will be your GP in freedom. Inform the prison medical worker of your release so that necessary digital prescriptions can be prepared.

Finances and debts

Upon release, the entire release fund accumulated in your account is paid out. If you still have outstanding debts, draw up a debt plan and agree on a payment schedule with the enforcement agent.

Support network and employment

Contact family members if possible, so you have an initial support network. Call the Unemployment Insurance Fund (Töötukassa) before release to learn what you need to do and what services are available. Note: you cannot register with Töötukassa while still in prison. Immediately after release, register with Töötukassa to begin job searching or participate in courses. Depending on your health, you may need to apply for a disability assessment.

Upon release, you must return all prison property issued to you. Do not leave personal items behind. If you lack suitable clothing for the weather upon release, prison will provide these.

8. WHO'S WHO — Prison Staff and Their Roles

Prison has various positions. Here is an overview of the staff who can primarily help you. Knowing who is responsible for what helps you get help more quickly.

Guard

The guard is the worker you will see most often in prison. The guard: makes rounds and conducts roll calls; ensures everyone follows the schedule and rules; monitors cameras; searches cells and other rooms; ensures food and medications are distributed; assists with phone and tablet use; relays information about your needs to the contact officer.

You can ask the guard about daily routine questions, e.g. how to use the phone or how to fill in a doctor's appointment form.

Contact Officer (Inspector-Contact Officer or Case Manager)

The contact officer is your main support in prison. For most questions, you should first approach them. They: meet you in the early days of imprisonment; plan your sentence and release together with you; arrange your participation in all activities (study, hobbies, programmes, therapy); help you send letters and applications; handle case-based issues (e.g. violations); communicate with your loved ones and probation officer; monitor together with you whether your ISP activities are working, and may initiate ISP changes.

Social Worker

The social worker conducts conversations and group activities to help you prepare for release. They organise and deliver social programmes, assess your motivation, support your development goals, and cooperate with other specialists. Contact your contact officer first to reach the social worker.

Psychologist

The psychologist supports you mentally and emotionally. They assess your psychological state, use various therapy forms, advise on coping with stress, and provide feedback to your contact officer. Conversations observe confidentiality requirements. Contact your contact officer first.

Chaplain

The chaplain provides spiritual and pastoral conversations, conducts prayer meetings and religious services, supports you in difficulties, and respects your religious beliefs. Contact your contact officer or guard to arrange a meeting.

Probation Officer (Case Manager in Probation)

The probation officer helps you act lawfully while serving your sentence in freedom. They meet with you regularly after early release, assess your needs and risks, direct you to fulfil court-imposed requirements, share progress and discuss setbacks, cooperate with the court and other specialists, and support communication with family and employers.

When approaching staff: think through your question and formulate it clearly. Use the specialist's time purposefully. Respect each worker's role. If unsure whom to approach, ask your contact officer or guard. All workers are here to support you — do not hesitate to ask for help or advice!

9. THE DETAINEE'S JOURNEY

Arrival

Upon arriving at prison, you undergo reception-related activities such as search and health check. Once complete, you move to the residential wing (unless on remand).

Prison daily life

As you adjust to prison daily life, it is good to familiarise yourself with the daily schedule, rules, obligations, and opportunities. Maintain calm and treat yourself, fellow detainees, and prison officers with goodwill.

Sentence progression and release planning (resocialisation)

From the very beginning of your imprisonment, we start preparing for your release together. You will receive a risk assessment and an Individual Sentence Plan (ISP). Together we discuss which activities and steps will help you live a law-abiding life in the future.

Activities include: conversations with your contact officer and other staff; social programmes; addiction support; ISP; studying; working; release fund; Estonian language study; and leisure activities.

Different pathways towards release

Open prison: Greater freedom and responsibility, continued ISP, work and study opportunities inside and outside prison.

Electronic supervision (ETEV): Ankle bracelet monitoring, living at home with restrictions, probation supervision.

Conditional early release (TEV): Serving sentence in freedom on probation with obligations and regular meetings.

Preparation for life in freedom

3–6 months before release, think through all the details of your future life. Check your ID card/passport validity. Think about where you will live and how to find work. Research support services and benefits. Register with Töötukassa immediately after release.

Explore which activities and programmes help you achieve early release or move to an open prison. If the first attempt does not succeed, you can try again. Both in open prison and on conditional early release, specific rules apply — be careful to comply with them so that violations do not bring you back to closed prison.